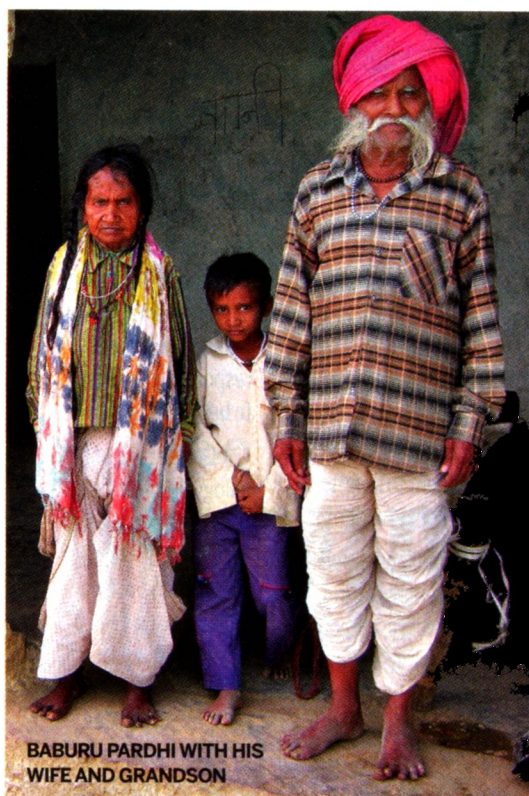




DAUWA WITH HIS FAMILY,
ALL OF WHOM ARE INTO
POACHING BUSINESS

Photographs by MIHIR SRIVASTAVA / www.indiatodayimages.com



BABURU PARDHI WITH HIS
WIFE AND GRANDSON

TRIBAL HUNTERS RECEIVE ORDERS, ESTIMATED TO BE FOR 60 TIGERS A YEAR, TO BE SKINNED AND BODY PARTS COLLECTED AND PRESERVED.

gles of Karnataka to get some “*chaddars*” (tiger skins) to meet current orders. Maur Lal, a Pardhi, agrees to take us to another village, Kuksi, in Harda district. The menfolk, we are told, should be out hunting but they come back to share the booty, connect with their family and procure more orders. Their official source of income is selling *rudraksh* procured from Nepal. Maur Lal explains: “We get it from Nepal, via Katni, Kanpur, Lucknow, Gorakhpur.” That also happens to be the route to smuggle out tiger parts into Nepal on its way to China. We meet ‘English’, the dreaded poacher on the run. English finds mention as one of the poachers responsible for hunting tigers in the

Special Investigation Team report by the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) on Panna along with others. His extended family includes the likes of Mintar Singh, who was arrested two years ago with 36 accomplices for poaching eight lions in Gir. Others like Daryawani and Lalarsi are still at large, operating with impunity, taking calls on their mobiles, discussing prices for tiger skins and parts, but only if you say you are from Fatehpur, where most of the orders to this group are sourced from.

While we were talking, a fat lady comes charging towards us, yelling: “I will tell you their real story. None of them belong here, they are from Katni, they are all criminals, they have killed

my daughter, they kill wild animals too. I cannot let them fool the Government.” She is Dabuliya Bai, head of a clan of the Pardhis. No one dares to stop her while she spews venom at the rival gang run by Kanthi Lal. Her own family record in killing tigers is unmatched. Her husband Raj Mahal with his gang is believed to have killed 35-40 tigers in Maharashtra and Karnataka. Her brother, Siddhe Singh, died in jail serving a sentence for tiger poaching. Daru, who operated in Gujarat and Karnataka and is under arrest for poaching, is a relative. She is believed to have delivered some 35 tiger skins to Sansar Chand, the most notorious trader of tiger skins. Her nephew, Ajit Pardhi, has made a fortune killing tigers and pays more than a lakh of premium on insurance policies in his, his wife and his brother-in-law’s name.

To find out why she is camping in Kuksi, we travel to Katni where we meet octogenarian Baburu Pardhi, a legendary figure in the community who has poached many tigers and leopards, but has never been arrested. Baburu has passed the baton to his five sons